

# Another Son RISES

The Congress faces a dilemma with the growing demand for handing over the reins of the state to YSR's son Jagan, a political novice but a major player now



**SONIA GANDHI WITH JAGAN REDDY AND KVP RAMACHANDRA RAO AT YSR'S FUNERAL IN HYDERABAD**

**By Amarnath K. Menon**

It is a troubling legacy that Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy leaves behind for the Congress in Andhra Pradesh. The massive outpouring of grief, including shock deaths and suicides, has transformed quickly into wholehearted endorsement for his only son Jaganmohan Reddy, 37, a first-term MP, to take over as chief minister of the state. The AICC was forced to sit up and take note rather than rely on the time-honoured party tradition of falling back on an experienced leader who can keep the flock together and provide responsible governance in a state. What it has run into in Andhra Pradesh is unprecedented,

for such solid support for any leader is unknown for some decades now in any of the big states where the Congress has come to power. The party is stunned to find that the vast majority of the 156 Congress legislators want Jagan to slip into the saddle.

This is hardly surprising, going by the manner in which YSR re-engineered the Congress to build a motivated party rank and file with a younger age profile. He spotted talent and inducted a new generation of first-time contestants who emerged winners in the polls. Now, the Congress is conscious of the fact that the perpetuation of his legacy is critical to the

future of the party in Andhra Pradesh. The decision to rename Kadapa as Rajasekhara Reddy district, the plan to install statues of YSR in all 294 assembly constituencies and several other initiatives in his memory announced in less than a week after his death is symptomatic of the need for the Congress to make the most of the sentiments from a tragic loss.

The overwhelming majority of influential party activists believe Jagan has the requisite leadership skills. His three fervent appeals in six days—first, requesting supporters to try and cope with the loss and shock instead of self-annihilation, second,